the mysterious end of Russia's first agent of the Great Game became the subject of speculation. The British believed the suicide was evidence of all that they most disliked and feared about the autocratic callousness of the Tsar's regime. Vitkevitch had, after all, been barbarously exiled from his native Poland to a punishment posting on the distant steppe at the age of only fourteen. Then, having worked his way up against all the odds and excelled as an intelligence agent, at the moment of his triumph, when he had outmanoeuvred his rival Burnes and won over the Barakzais, he had been callously disowned and cast out by his Russian masters.

The British Ambassador in St Petersburg wrote to Palmerston that 'the cause is said to have been the disapprobation & disavowal of his conduct in Afghanistan by the Russ. Govt. instead of the reward & promotion he expected'.[2] According to Russian 'refugees and émigrés' contacted by Sir John Kaye when he was enquiring into the matter in the late 1840s, Vitkevitch had arrived in the capital 'full of hope, for he had discharged the duty entrusted to him with admirable address'. But Count Nesselrode had refused to receive him, and when he presented himself at the Ministry he had been turned away. The Count had sent word that he 'knew no Captain Vitkevitch, except an adventurer of that name, who it is reported, has lately been engaged in some unauthorised intrigues in Kabul and Kandahar'. Vitkevitch 'understood at once the dire portent of the message. He knew the character of his government.' Aware that in the apparently successful British invasion of Afghanistan he had already been checkmated by Burnes, he now 'saw clearly' that in addition 'he was sacrificed' by the politicians he had served so faithfully and effectively.[3]

The British agent and news-writer in Bukhara, Nazir Khan Ullah, independently confirmed this version of events in a secret despatch sent from Central Asia. Vitkevitch had felt himself compromised when his superiors failed to honour his promises of military support to the Barakzais, leaving them to face the British alone. 'The Russian agent here is my acquaintance,' wrote Nazir Khan to his handler, Burnes. 'He said that when Vitkevitch returned from Kabul to Russia, he told the Russian authorities that he had sent them many letters soliciting Military and Pecuniary assistance and that they never sent him any reply, and delayed the business, and that this neglect had made him out a liar in the country of Kabul and Kandahar. He therefore felt disgraced, and on hearing of the answer of the Cabinet of St. Petersburg, he shot himself.'[4]